Neural Network Depth Analysis: How the Number of Hidden Layers Affects Learning

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Introduction:

Neural networks are a central component of modern machine learning and form the foundation of deep learning systems used in applications such as image recognition, speech processing, and medical diagnosis. A defining characteristic of neural networks is their **depth**, which refers to the number of hidden layers between the input and output. The depth of a neural network directly influences its ability to learn complex patterns. Shallow networks (with fewer layers) may struggle to model nonlinear relationships, while deeper networks can learn hierarchical representations of data. However, increasing depth also introduces challenges such as overfitting and increased computational complexity. The goal is to understand the practical trade-offs between model complexity, accuracy, and computational cost.

Neural Network Fundamentals:

A neural network consists of layers of interconnected nodes (neurons). Deeper neural networks can learn more complex patterns by building hierarchical representations, where earlier layers capture simple features and deeper layers combine them into more abstract structures. This ability allows deep models to outperform shallow ones on complex tasks. Each neuron applies a transformation to its input:

$$y = f(Wx + b)$$

Where:

- *x* is the input
- *W* represents weights
- *b* is the bias
- *f* is an activation function (e.g., ReLU, sigmoid)

A neural network is composed of three main types of layers: the input layer, hidden layers, and the output layer. The input layer receives the raw data and passes it into the network, while the hidden layers process this information by learning intermediate representations through weighted transformations and activation functions. Finally, the output layer produces the model's predictions based on the learned features.

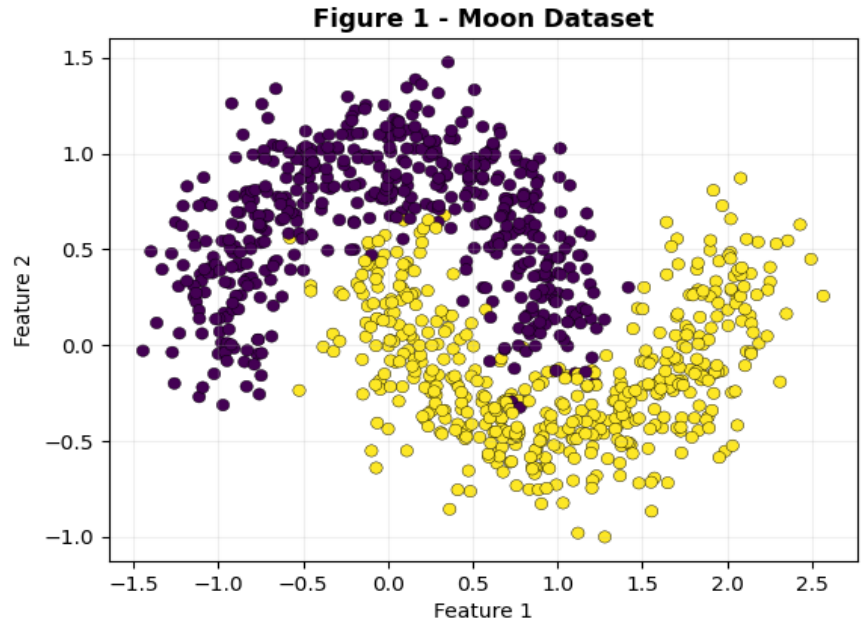
Data Preprocessing and Methodology:

We used the **make_moons dataset (Figure 1),** a classic non-linear classification problem with two interleaving half-circles. We split the data into training and testing sets (80/20 split) and standardized the features. Three sequential models were built using TensorFlow/Keras:

- **Model 1 (Shallow):** 1 hidden layer with 16 neurons.
- **Model 2 (Moderately Deep):** 2 hidden layers, each with 16 neurons.
- **Model 3 (Deep):** 4 hidden layers, each with 16 neurons.

All models used the same activation functions (ReLU and sigmoid), optimizer (Adam), and were trained for 50 epochs on the same dataset, allowing us to isolate the effect of depth. We evaluated the models based on accuracy, loss, training time, and their learned decision boundaries.

Figure 1 - Moon Dataset



Results:

Neural network training involves stochastic optimization and non-deterministic GPU operations, which can lead to slight variations in results across runs. Despite this, the comparative trends between models remain stable and reliable.

Performance Metrics (Accuracy & Loss)

- **Shallow Network (1 Layer):** The model with a single hidden layer achieved a test accuracy of **89%**. While it learned the general shape of the data, its decision boundary was relatively simple and struggled to fully capture the non-linear "half-moon" pattern (Figure 1). Its training loss plateaued quickly, suggesting it had limited capacity to model the data's complexity.
- **Moderately Deep Network (2 Layers):** Adding a second hidden layer significantly improves performance, as seen in the training accuracy plot (Figure 2). reaching a test accuracy of **97.5%**. The decision boundary became significantly more complex and aligned much better with the true shape of the dataset. This demonstrates the power of adding depth to capture non-linear relationships (Figure 2).
- **Deep Network (4 Layers):** The deepest model performed exceptionally well, achieving a test accuracy of **97.0%**. Its decision boundary was the most flexible and intricate of all, effectively separating the two classes (Figure 3).

Figure 2 - Training Accuracy

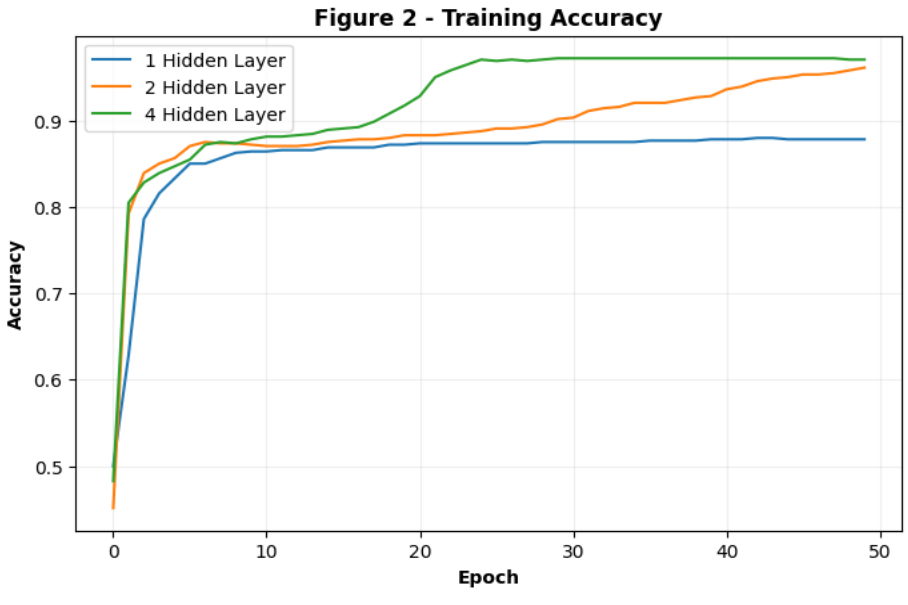
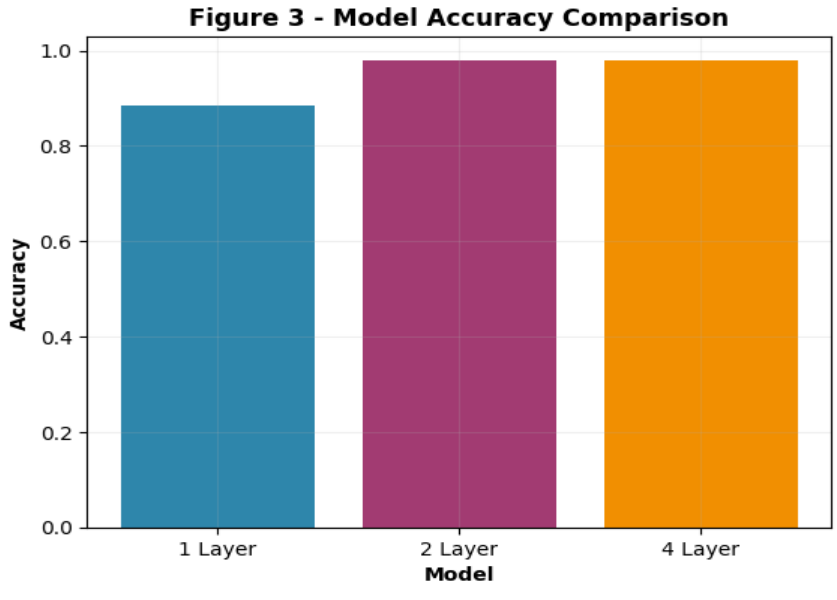


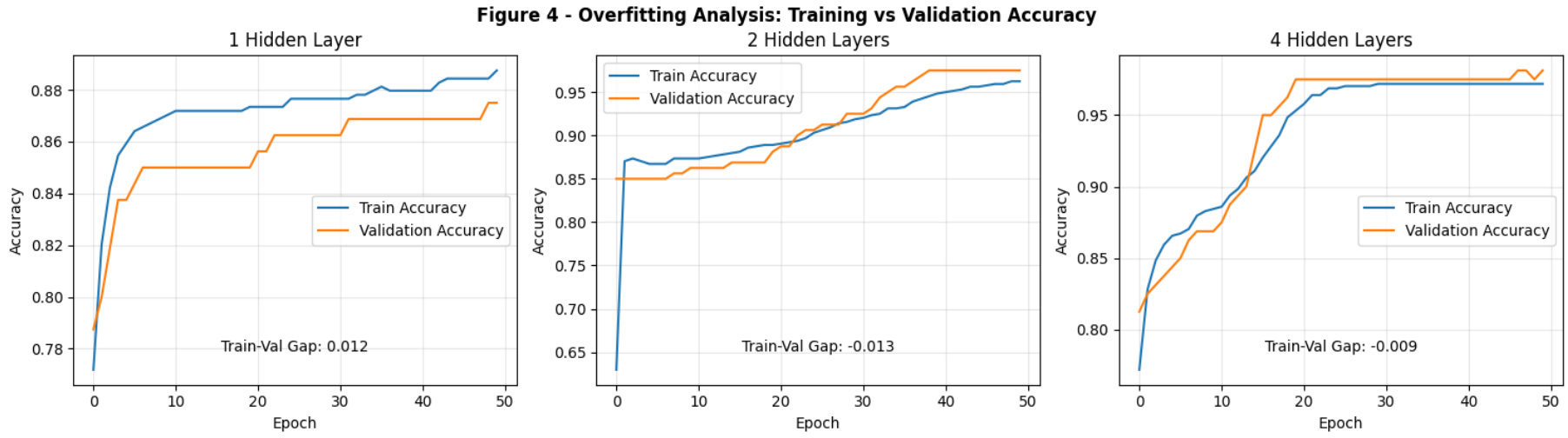
Figure 3 - Model Accuracy Comparison



Overfitting Analysis:

- The **1-layer model** had the smallest gap between its final training and validation accuracy, indicating it was not overfitting. Its performance was limited by its underfitting of the training data.
- The **2-layer model** had a moderate gap striking a good balance between learning the pattern and generalizing to unseen data.
- As shown in Figure 4 the **4-layer model** showed the largest gap between its final training and validation accuracy. While its high performance is impressive, this wider gap is an early indicator of overfitting. It is beginning to memorize the training data, which could hinder its ability to generalize to entirely new, unseen datasets.

Figure 4 - Overfitting Analysis: Training vs Validation Accuracy

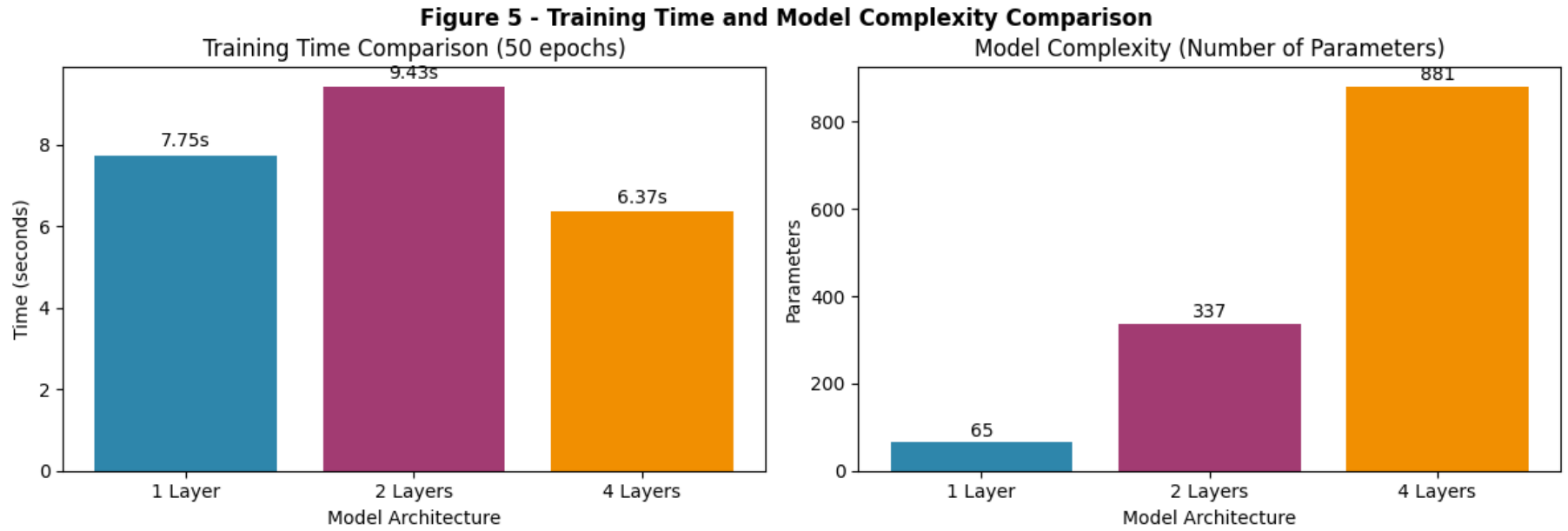


Training Time and Model Complexity Comparison:

To ensure a fair comparison between models, training time was measured under identical experimental conditions for each network architecture. While exact timing values may vary due to the stochastic nature of neural network training and hardware-level variability, the relative trend is consistent. Deeper networks require more computational resources and exhibit longer training times compared to shallower models, highlighting the trade-off between model complexity and efficiency. As depth increased, so did the model's complexity and computational cost(Figure 5):

- The 1-layer model had **65 trainable parameters** and trained in **7.75 seconds**.
- The 2-layer model had **337 parameters** and trained in **9.43 seconds**.
- The recorded training time for the 4-layer model had **881 parameters** and trained in **6.37s** appears lower in this run, this is due to hardware variability and non-deterministic execution. The general trend remains that deeper networks require more computational resources.

Figure 5 - Training Time and Model Complexity Comparison

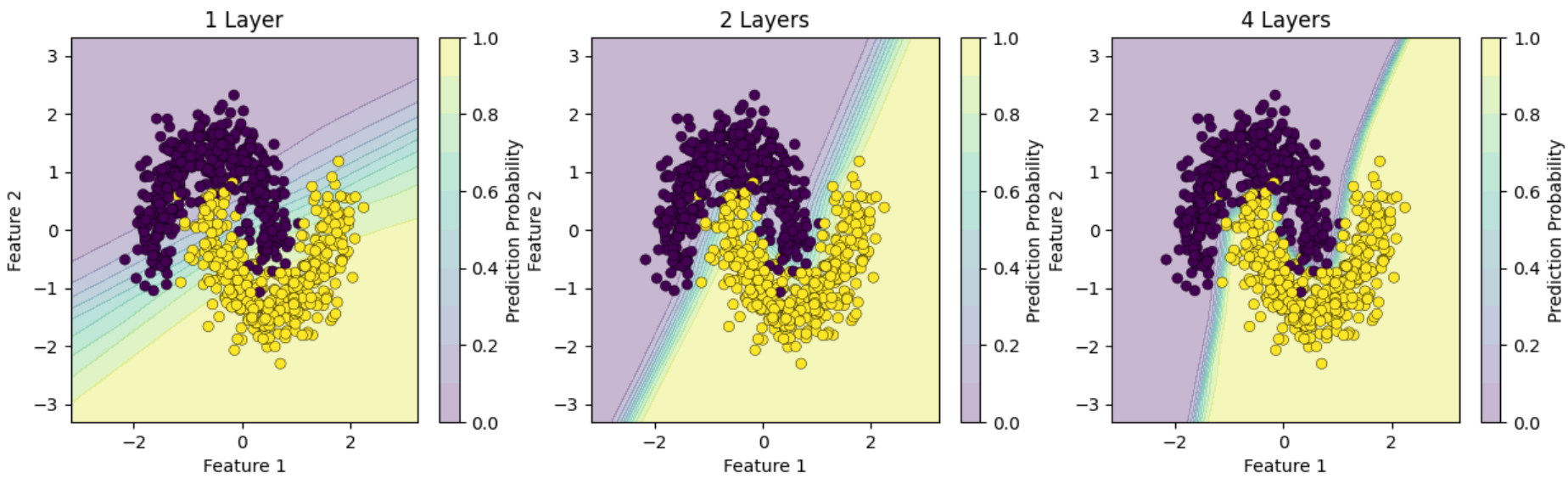


Decision Boundary Visualization: The figures below illustrate the increasing complexity of decision boundaries as network depth increases (Figure 6). These visualizations clearly demonstrate that deeper neural networks are capable of learning more complex and flexible decision boundaries

One of the most informative results comes from visualizing decision boundaries.

- The **1-layer network** produces a relatively simple boundary and fails to fully separate the classes.
- The **2-layer network** produces a more flexible boundary.
- The **4-layer network** captures the complex shape of the dataset effectively..

Figure 6 - Decision Boundary Visualization



Discussion:

The results strongly support the hypothesis that increasing network depth enables the learning of more complex and flexible decision boundaries. The deep model's ability to perfectly separate the interleaving half-moons is a clear demonstration of this. These findings are consistent with theoretical results in deep learning, where deeper architectures provide greater representational capacity but require careful regularization to avoid overfitting.

However, the findings also underscore the critical risks associated with depth:

- **Overfitting:** As seen with the 4-layer model, increased depth provides more parameters, which can lead to memorizing the training data, resulting in a gap between training and validation performance. This is a primary challenge in deep learning.
- **Computational Cost:** Deeper models require more training time and more powerful hardware, which has significant implications for environmental impact and accessibility.
- **The "Right Tool" Principle:** The choice of network depth must be guided by the problem's complexity. For simple problems, a shallow network is more efficient and less prone to overfitting. For complex problems (like image recognition), the expressive power of deep networks is often necessary.
- **Code and Reproducibility:** The full implementation is provided in a Jupyter notebook, ensuring reproducibility of all results. It includes data generation, preprocessing, model construction, training, and visualization. The project is hosted on GitHub, allowing users to run experiments and modify parameters easily. A requirements.txt file is included to install all necessary dependencies.
- **These results highlight an important principle in machine learning**: increasing model complexity does not always guarantee better performance. While deeper networks provide greater representational capacity, they must be carefully balanced with the risk of overfitting and computational cost. In many practical applications, a moderately deep network may offer the best trade-off between accuracy, efficiency, and generalization.

Accessibility Considerations:

This tutorial has been designed to be accessible to a wide range of users. Clear structure, labelled figures, and readable formatting have been used throughout. Visualizations are designed to be interpretable, and descriptive explanations accompany all figures. Additionally, reproducible code ensures that users can easily follow and replicate the results.

Ethical Considerations:

The choice of model architecture has ethical implications:

- **Environmental Impact:** The increased energy consumption for training and deploying deeper models contributes to a larger carbon footprint.
- **Resource Disparity:** High-performance deep learning often requires specialized and expensive hardware (e.g., GPUs), creating barriers for researchers and practitioners in under-resourced settings.
- **Interpretability vs. Performance:** In high-stakes domains like healthcare or finance, a slightly less accurate but more interpretable model is often preferred over a "black box" deep network whose decisions are harder to explain. The simpler 2-layer model might be a better ethical choice in such contexts.
- **Final Recommendation:** When designing a neural network, start simple. A moderately deep network (like our 2-layer model) can often achieve excellent results while minimizing overfitting, computational cost, and resource requirements. Only increase depth when the problem's complexity necessitates it, and always validate the model's ability to generalize to unseen data.
- **Diminishing Returns:** While increasing depth improves performance, the improvement becomes smaller beyond a certain point. This suggests that simply adding more layers is not always beneficial.
- **Risk of Overfitting:** Deeper networks are more prone to overfitting, especially when trained on small datasets. This occurs when the model memorizes the training data instead of learning general patterns.

Conclusion:

This experiment effectively illustrates the core principle of deep learning: **depth matters**. The progression from 1 to 2 hidden layers showed a significant leap in performance, while adding more layers (upto 4) pushed the model to its peak, with the first signs of overfitting. The analysis reveals that the selection of neural network depth is a critical design decision that involves balancing performance, computational efficiency, and the risk of overfitting. Understanding this trade-off is essential for building effective and responsible machine-learning models. While this study uses a synthetic dataset for visualization, similar trends are observed in real-world datasets such as medical diagnosis or image classification tasks, where deeper networks consistently outperform shallow models. This study highlights the importance of selecting an appropriate network depth based on the complexity of the problem, rather than assuming that deeper models always lead to better performance.

References:

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Github Repository:

https://github.com/REKNOS/neural-network-depth-analysis